PO33Q - The Life and Death of Democracies and Dictatorships: A Quantitative Perspective

Codebook

Dr Florian Linke

Florian.Linke@warwick.ac.uk

Table 1: Codebook PO33Q

Variable	Label
countrycode	Country Code
country	Country Name
year	Year
polity5	Combined Polity V Score
democracy	0 = Autocracy, 1 = Democracy (Miller et al., 2022)
gdppc	GDP per capita (current US Dollars)
gdppc_growth	GDP per capita growth (%)
enrol_gross	School enrollment, primary (% gross)
primcomp	Primary completion rate (% of relevant age group)
primcom_male	Primary completion rate, male (% of relevant age group)
primcom_fem	Primary completion rate, female (% of relevant age group)
enrol_net	School enrollment, primary (% net)
agri	Agriculture, forestry, and fishing, value added (% of GDP)
slums	Population living in slums (% of urban population)
telephone	Households with telephones (Landline & Mobile, %)
internet	Individuals using the Internet (% of population)
tax	Tax revenue (% of GDP)
pop	Population, total
pop_fem	Population, female (% of total population)
electricity	Access to electricity (% of total population)
service	Services, value added (% of GDP)
oil	Oil rents (% of GDP)
natural	Total natural resources rents (% of GDP)
oda	Net official development assistance and official aid received (constant 2021 US$)
literacy	Literacy rate, adult total (% of people ages 15 and above)
lit_male	Literacy rate, adult male (% of males ages 15 and above)
lit_fem	Literacy rate, adult female (% of males ages 15 and above)
infant	Mortality rate, infant (per 1,000 live births)
health_ex	Current health expenditure (% of GDP)
hospital	Hospital beds (per 1,000 people)
tuberculosis	Incidence of tuberculosis (per 100,000 people)

continued on next page

UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK

life	Life expectancy at birth, total (years)
life_male	Life expectancy at birth, male (years)
life_female	Life expectancy at birth, female (years)
unemploy	Unemployed (%)
urban	Urban population, total (% of total population)
attend	Births attended by skilled health staff (% of total)
prenatal	Pregnant women receiving prenatal care of at least four visits
military	Military Expenditure (% of GDP)
un_continent_name	Continent
un_region_name	Region on continent
v2x_libdem	VDem Liberal democracy index
v2x_regime	VDem Regimes of the World Index
v2xcs_ccsi	How robust is civil society? Source(s): v2cseeorgs v2csreprss v2csprtcpt
v2cseeorgs	Civil Society – entry and exit
v2csreprss	Civil Society – repression
v2cscnsult	Civil Society – consultation
v2csprtcpt	Civil Society – participatory environment
v2csgender	Civil Society – women's participation
v2csantimv	Civil Society – anti-system movements
v2csrlgrep	Religious organization repression
v2csrlgcon	Religious organization consultation
v2regsupgroups_0	Regime failure without support: The aristocracy, including high status hereditary social groups and castes
v2regsupgroups_1	Regime failure without support: Agrarian elites, including rich peasants and large landholders.
v2regsupgroups_2	Regime failure without support: Party elites (of the party or parties that control the executive)
v2regsupgroups_3	Regime failure without support: Business elites
v2regsupgroups_4	Regime failure without support: The state bureaucracy
v2regsupgroups_5	Regime failure without support: The military
v2regsupgroups_6	Regime failure without support: An ethnic or racial group(s)
v2regsupgroups_7	Regime failure without support: A religious group(s)
v2regsupgroups_8	Regime failure without support: Local elites, including customary chiefs
v2regsupgroups_9	Regime failure without support: Urban working classes, including labor unions
v2regsupgroups_10	Regime failure without support: Urban middle classes
v2regsupgroups_11	Regime failure without support: Rural working classes (e.g., peasants)
v2regsupgroups_12	Regime failure without support: Rural middle classes (e.g., family farmers)
v2regsupgroups_13	Regime failure without support: A foreign government or colonial power

continued on next page

v2x_neopat	Neopatrimonial rule index
v2dlencmps	Neopatrimonial rule index: Particularistic or public goods
v2elembaut	Neopatrimonial rule index: EMB autonomy
v2elvotbuy	Neopatrimonial rule index: Election vote buying
v2exbribe	Neopatrimonial rule index: Executive bribery and corrupt exchanges
v2exembez	Neopatrimonial rule index: Executive embezzlement and theft
v2exrescon	Neopatrimonial rule index: Executive respects constitution
v2jucomp	Neopatrimonial rule index: Compliance with judiciary
v2jucorrdc	Neopatrimonial rule index: Judicial corruption decision
v2juhccomp	Neopatrimonial rule index: Compliance with high court
v2juhcind	Neopatrimonial rule index: High court independence
v2juncind	Neopatrimonial rule index: Lower court independence
v2lgcrrpt	Neopatrimonial rule index: Legislature corrupt activities
v2lgfunds	Neopatrimonial rule index: Legislature controls resources
v2lginvstp	Neopatrimonial rule index: Legislature investigates in practice
v2lgotovst	Neopatrimonial rule index: Executive oversight
v2psprlnks	Neopatrimonial rule index: Party linkages
v2xnp_client	Clientelism index
v2dlencmps	Clientelism index: Particularistic or public goods
v2elvotbuy	Clientelism index: Election vote buying
v2psprlnks	Clientelism index: Party linkages

The data are taken from Coppedge et al. (2025), Marshall and Gurr (2020), Miller et al. (2022) and World Bank (n.d.).

Excerpts from the V-Dem Codebook

These variable specifications are extracted from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Codebook, v15. Full codebook available at v-dem.net.

3.5.1.7 Regime Support Groups (C)

`v2regsupgroups`

Project Manager(s): Carl Henrik Knutsen

Additional versions: `*_nr`

Question: Which groups does the current political regime rely on in order to maintain power? (Check all that apply.)

Clarification: Consider which group(s) is supportive of the regime, and, if it/they were to retract support would substantially increase the chance that the regime would lose power.

Responses:

Code	Description	Variable
0	The aristocracy, including high status hereditary social groups and castes.	`v2regsupgroups_0`
1	Agrarian elites, including rich peasants and large landholders.	`v2regsupgroups_1`
2	Party elites (of the party or parties that control the executive).	`v2regsupgroups_2`
3	Business elites.	`v2regsupgroups_3`
4	The state bureaucracy.	`v2regsupgroups_4`
5	The military.	`v2regsupgroups_5`
6	An ethnic or racial group(s).	`v2regsupgroups_6`
7	A religious group(s).	`v2regsupgroups_7`
8	Local elites, including customary chiefs.	`v2regsupgroups_8`
9	Urban working classes, including labor unions.	`v2regsupgroups_9`
10	Urban middle classes.	`v2regsupgroups_10`
11	Rural working classes (e.g., peasants).	`v2regsupgroups_11`
12	Rural middle classes (e.g., family farmers).	`v2regsupgroups_12`
13	A foreign government or colonial power.	`v2regsupgroups_13`

Scale	Mean-aggregated scores of dichotomized variable
Answer-type	Multiple-selection
Data release	9–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Mean
Cleaning	Set to missing where `v2regint` is 0
Years	1789–2023
Default date	January 1

Citation: V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.11 Civil Society

Instructions to coders: Civil society organizations (CSOs) include interest groups, labor unions, religiously inspired organizations (if engaged in civic or political activities), social movements, professional associations, and classic NGOs—but not businesses, political parties, government agencies, or religious organizations primarily focused on spiritual practices. A CSO must be at least nominally independent of government and economic institutions.

Historical clarification: If no CSOs exist at all for a particular time period, code the relevant questions as giving the lowest score (indicating, e.g., strong repression or no consultation, a 0).

Religious organizations: Two questions in this section address religious organizations, which may be religiously inspired CSOs or organizations whose purpose is primarily spiritual.

3.11.1 General

3.11.1.1 CSO Entry and Exit (C)

`v2cseeorgs`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: To what extent does the government achieve control over entry and exit by civil society organizations (CSOs) into public life?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Monopolistic control.** The government exercises an explicit monopoly over CSOs. The only organizations allowed to engage in political activity are government-sponsored. The government actively represses those who attempt to defy its monopoly.
1	**Substantial control.** The government licenses all CSOs and uses political criteria to bar organizations likely to oppose it. At least some citizen-based organizations play a limited independent role. The government actively represses those who flout its political criteria.
2	**Moderate control.** Whether the ban on independent CSOs is partial or full, some prohibited organizations manage to play an active political role. The government does not or cannot repress them.
3	**Minimal control.** Constitutional provisions allow the government to ban organizations with a history of anti-democratic action (e.g., banning of neo-fascist or communist organizations in the FRG). Such banning takes place under strict rule of law and judicial independence.
4	**Unconstrained.** The government does not impede CSO formation and operation unless they are engaged in activities to violently overthrow the government.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.2 CSO Repression (C)

`v2csreprss`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Does the government attempt to repress civil society organizations (CSOs)?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Severely.** The government violently pursues all real and even some imagined members of CSOs, seeking to effectively liquidate them. Examples: Stalinist Russia, Nazi Germany, Maoist China.
1	**Substantially.** The government arrests, tries, and imprisons leaders and participants in oppositional CSOs who have acted lawfully. Other sanctions include disruption of gatherings and violent sanctions. Examples: Mugabe's Zimbabwe, Poland under Martial Law.
2	**Moderately.** The government engages in minor legal harassment (detentions, short-term incarceration) and may restrict association or block international contacts. Examples: post-Martial Law Poland, Brazil in the early 1980s.
3	**Weakly.** The government uses material sanctions (fines, firings, denial of social services) and burdensome registration procedures. May organize GONGOs. Example: Putin's Russia.
4	**No.** CSOs are free to organize, associate, strike, express themselves, and criticize the government without fear of sanctions or harassment.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Note: As of December 2014, responses are reversed so that 0 = least democratic, 4 = most democratic.

3.11.1.3 CSO Consultation (C)

`v2cscnsult`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Are major civil society organizations (CSOs) routinely consulted by policymakers on policies relevant to their members?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**No.** High degree of insulation from CSO input. The government may mobilize CSOs after policies are adopted but does not consult them in formulating policies.
1	**To some degree.** CSOs are but one set of voices that policymakers sometimes take into account.
2	**Yes.** Important CSOs are recognized as stakeholders in important policy areas. This can be accomplished through formal corporatist or less formal arrangements.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.4 CSO Structure (C)

`v2csstruc`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_nr`

Question: Characterize the relative influence of large mass constituency CSOs versus smaller, more local, or narrowly construed CSOs.

Responses:

Code	Description	Variable
0	The state does not allow autonomous CSOs.	`v2csstruc_0`
1	**Large encompassing organizations dominate.** Government and CSOs are linked through corporatism; particular large CSOs are highly influential.	`v2csstruc_1`
2	**Neither large nor small CSOs dominate.** Influence is contingent on circumstances; organizations of both sizes contend with one another.	`v2csstruc_2`
3	**Small CSOs dominate.** Many small organizations contend to have their voices heard.	`v2csstruc_3`

Scale	Mean-aggregated scores of dichotomized variable
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.5 CSO Participatory Environment (C)

`v2csprtcpt`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Which of these best describes the involvement of people in civil society organizations (CSOs)?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	Most associations are state-sponsored; participation is not purely voluntary.
1	Voluntary CSOs exist but few people are active in them.
2	There are many diverse CSOs, but popular involvement is minimal.
3	There are many diverse CSOs and it is considered normal for people to be at least occasionally active in at least one.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.6 CSO Women's Participation (C)

`v2csgender`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Are women prevented from participating in civil society organizations (CSOs)?

Clarification: Consider both (A) whether women are prevented from participating in CSOs because of their gender and (B) whether CSOs pursuing women's interests are prevented from taking part in associational life.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	Almost always.
1	Frequently.
2	About half the time.
3	Rarely.
4	Almost never.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.7 CSO Anti-System Movements (C)

`v2csantimv`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Among civil society organizations, are there anti-system opposition movements?

Clarification: An anti-system opposition movement is any movement—peaceful or armed—that is based in the country (not abroad) and is organized in opposition to the current political system. It aims to change the polity in fundamental ways (e.g., democratic to autocratic, capitalist to communist, secular to fundamentalist). It may be linked to an electoral party but must have a mass base and existence separate from normal electoral competition.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**No, or very minimal.** Anti-system movements are practically nonexistent.
1	Low-level activity; does not pose much threat to the regime.
2	Modest level of activity, posing some threat to the regime.
3	High level of activity, posing substantial threat to the regime.
4	Very high level of activity, posing a real and present threat to the regime.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024
Convergence	Issues with universal thresholds

Ordering: If coded “0”, skip the following questions on anti-system movements.

3.11.1.8 CSO Anti-System Movement Character (C)

`v2csanmvch`

Project Manager(s): Michael Bernhard

Additional versions: `*_nr`

Question: How would you characterize the anti-system movement(s) identified in the previous question? (Check all that apply.)

Responses:

Code	Description	Variable
0	Works through legal channels, for the most part.	`v2csanmvch_0`
1	Participates in elections.	`v2csanmvch_1`
2	Works through a mix of legal and extra-legal channels.	`v2csanmvch_2`
3	Insurrectionary.	`v2csanmvch_3`
4	Democratic. Perceived as willing to play by democratic rules, respect constitutional provisions, and relinquish power.	`v2csanmvch_4`
5	Anti-democratic. Perceived as unwilling to play by democratic rules or relinquish power.	`v2csanmvch_5`
6	Leftist, socialist, communist.	`v2csanmvch_6`
7	Rightist, conservative, party of order.	`v2csanmvch_7`
8	Ethnolinguistic, tribe, kinship, clan.	`v2csanmvch_8`
9	Separatist or autonomist.	`v2csanmvch_9`
10	Religious.	`v2csanmvch_10`
11	Paramilitary.	`v2csanmvch_11`
12	Heavily engaged in criminal activity (e.g., narcotics, extortion, kidnapping).	`v2csanmvch_12`

Scale	Mean-aggregated scores of dichotomized variable
Answer-type	Multiple-selection
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.9 Religious Organization Repression (C)

`v2csrlgrep`

Project Manager(s): Michael Coppedge

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Does the government attempt to repress religious organizations?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Severely.** The government violently pursues all real and even some imagined members of religious organizations, seeking to liquidate them. Examples: Stalinist Russia, Maoist China.
1	**Substantially.** The government arrests, tries, and imprisons leaders and participants who acted lawfully. Includes disruption of gatherings and violent sanctions.
2	**Moderately.** Minor legal harassment (detentions, short-term incarceration); may restrict association or block international contacts.
3	**Weakly.** Material sanctions (fines, firings, denial of services); burdensome registration; may organize parallel religious organizations.
4	**No.** Religious organizations are free to organize, associate, strike, express themselves, and criticize the government without fear of sanctions.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

3.11.1.10 Religious Organization Consultation (C)

`v2csrlgcon`

Project Manager(s): Michael Coppedge

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Are major religious organizations routinely consulted by policymakers on policies relevant to their members?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**No.** High degree of insulation from religious organization input. The government may mobilize them after policies are adopted but does not consult them in formulating policies.
1	**To some degree.** Religious organizations are but one set of voices that policymakers sometimes take into account.
2	**Yes.** Important religious organizations are recognized as stakeholders in important policy areas, through formal or informal arrangements.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

2.1.2 Liberal democracy index (D)

`v2x_libdem`

Project Manager(s): Jan Teorell

Additional versions: `*_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd`

Question: To what extent is the ideal of liberal democracy achieved?

Clarification: The liberal principle of democracy emphasizes the importance of protecting individual and minority rights against the tyranny of the state and the tyranny of the majority. The liberal model takes a "negative" view of political power insofar as it judges the quality of democracy by the limits placed on government. This is achieved by constitutionally protected civil liberties, strong rule of law, an independent judiciary, and effective checks and balances that, together, limit the exercise of executive power. To make this a measure of liberal democracy, the index also takes the level of electoral democracy into account.

Scale: Interval, from low to high (0–1).

Source(s): `v2x_liberal` `v2x_polyarchy`

Aggregation: The index is aggregated using this formula:

$$\texttt{v2x_libdem} = 0.25 \cdot \texttt{v2x_polyarchy}^{1.585} + 0.25 \cdot \texttt{v2x_liberal} + 0.5 \cdot \texttt{v2x_polyarchy}^{1.585} \cdot \texttt{v2x_liberal}$$

Data release	1–15. Release 1, 2, and 3 used a different, preliminary aggregation formula.
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Coppedge et al. (2015); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

5.1 Regimes of the World (RoW)

5.1.1 Regimes of the world – the RoW measure (D)

`v2x_regime`

Project Manager(s): Marcus Tannenberg, Staffan I Lindberg

Question: How can the political regime overall be classified considering the competitiveness of access to power (polyarchy) as well as liberal principles?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Closed autocracy** No multiparty elections for the chief executive or the legislature.
1	**Electoral autocracy** De-jure multiparty elections for the chief executive and the legislature, but failing to achieve that elections are free and fair, or de-facto multiparty, or a minimum level of Dahl's institutional prerequisites of polyarchy as measured by V-Dem's Electoral Democracy Index (`v2x_polyarchy`).
2	**Electoral democracy** De-facto free and fair multiparty elections and a minimum level of Dahl's institutional prerequisites for polyarchy as measured by V- Dem's Electoral Democracy Index (`v2x_polyarchy`), but either access to justice, or transparent law enforcement, or liberal principles of respect for personal liberties, rule of law, and judicial as well as legislative constraints on the executive not satisfied as measured by V-Dem's Liberal Component Index (`v2x_liberal`).
3	**Liberal democracy** De-facto free and fair multiparty elections and a minimum level of Dahl's institutional prerequisites for polyarchy as measured by V-Dem's Electoral Democracy Index (`v2x_polyarchy`) are guaranteed as well as access to justice, transparent law enforcement and the liberal principles of respect for personal liberties, rule of law, and judicial as well as legislative constraints on the executive satisfied as measured by V-Dem's Liberal Component Index (`v2x_liberal`).

Scale: Ordinal

Source(s): `v2x_elecreg` `v2xlg_elecreg` `v2xex_elecreg` `v2elmulpar_osp_ex` `v2elmulpar_osp_leg` `v2elmulpar_osp` `v2elfrfair_osp` `v2elfrfair_osp_leg` `v2elfrfair_osp_ex` `v2expathhg` `v2expathhs` `v2ex_legconhos` `v2ex_hosw` `v2x_polyarchy` `v2x_liberal` `v2clacjstm_osp` `v2clacjstw_osp` `v2cltrnslw_osp` `v2exaphogp`

Aggregation: Electoral democracies score above 2 on the indicators for multi–party (`v2elmulpar_osp`) and free and fair elections (`v2elfrfair_osp`), as well as above 0.5 on the Electoral Democracy Index (`v2x_polyarchy`). Liberal democracy meets the criteria for Electoral democracy but also satisfy the liberal dimensions by a score above 0.8 on the V–Dem Liberal Component index (`v2x_liberal`), as well as a score above 3 on transparent law enforcement (`v2cltrnslw_osp`), access to justice for men (`v2clacjstm_osp`) and women (`v2clacjstw_osp`). Electoral autocracies fail to meet one or more of the above–mentioned criteria of electoral democracies, but subject the chief executive and the legislature to de–jure multiparty elections as indicated by a score above 1 on the V–Dem multiparty elections indicator (`v2elmulpar_osp`). Closed autocracy if either no multiparty elections for the legislature take place (`v2xlg_elecreg` == 0) or the chief executive is not elected in direct or indirect multiparty elections. To identify whether this is the case, we take into account if there is no basic multiparty competition in elections (`v2elmulpar_osp` < 1) and the relative power of the Head of State (HoS) and the Head of Government (HoG) as well as the appointment procedures. The V–Dem variable `v2ex_hosw` identifies if the HoS (`v2ex_hosw` > 0.5) or HoG (`v2ex_hosw` < or equal to 0.5) is the chief executive. If the HoG is the chief executive, the variable `v2expathhg` indicates whether the HoG is directly (8) or indirectly (7) elected or appointed by the HoS (6). In the first case, we consider whether executive elections (`v2xex_elecreg` == 0) take place, in the second case whether legislative elections take place

Data release	9-15.
Years	1900-2024

Citation: Lührmann et al. (2018); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

5.4 Neopatrimonialism

5.4.1 Neopatrimonial Rule Index (D)

`v2x_neopat`

Project Manager(s): Carl Henrik Knutsen

Additional versions: `*_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd`

Question: To what extent is the political system characterized by neopatrimonial rule?

Clarification: Neopatrimonialism is an informal political system where officeholders use their positions for personal enrichment and to distribute resources to clients. It combines patrimonial (clientelistic, personalistic) and legal-rational (bureaucratic) elements. The index captures three interrelated dimensions: clientelism, presidentialism (concentration of power in the executive and lack of institutional checks), and regime corruption.

Scale: Interval, from low to high (0–1).

Source(s): `v2xnp_client` `v2xnp_pres` `v2xnp_regcorr`

Aggregation: The index is formed by taking the point estimates from a Bayesian factor analysis model of the three sub-indices: clientelism index (`v2xnp_client`), presidentialism index (`v2xnp_pres`), and regime corruption (`v2xnp_regcorr`).

Data release	8–15
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Convergence: Model parameters with convergence issues: country-date latent variable estimates.

Citation: Sigman & Lindberg (2018); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

5.4.2 Clientelism Index (D)

`v2xnp_client`

Project Manager(s): Carl Henrik Knutsen

Additional versions: `*_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd`

Question: To what extent are politics based on clientelistic relationships?

Clarification: Clientelism refers to the targeted provision of benefits to individuals, families, or small groups rather than the population at large. This index measures the degree to which political actors use particularistic goods as a strategy for winning elections and retaining political support.

Scale: Interval, from low to high (0–1).

Source(s): `v2dlencmps` `v2elvotbuy` `v2psprlnks`

Aggregation: The index is formed by taking the point estimates from a Bayesian factor analysis model of the indicators for particularistic or public goods (`v2dlencmps`), election vote buying (`v2elvotbuy`), and party linkages (`v2psprlnks`).

Data release	8–15
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1900–2024

Citation: Sigman & Lindberg (2018); Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.7.1.6 Particularistic or public goods (C)

`v2dlencmps`

Project Manager(s): John Gerring

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Considering the profile of spending, how much of the social and infrastructural expenditure is particularistic—going to specific localities, groups, or constituencies—versus public goods?

Clarification: Consider all social and infrastructural spending, at all levels of government. Please try to assess spending in practice rather than what may be stipulated by law, though legal changes are likely to affect practice. Spending is particularistic if the benefits of the spending flow to a certain group, constituency, or locality to the exclusion of others. Spending is public goods if it covers broad categories of people regardless of their affiliations.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Almost all particularistic.** Most social and infrastructural spending goes to a few specific localities, groups, or constituencies.
1	**Mostly particularistic.** Social and infrastructural spending is more particularistic than public-goods in character.
2	**A mix.** Social and infrastructural spending is a mix of particularistic and public-goods in character.
3	**Mostly public goods.** Social and infrastructural spending is more public-goods than particularistic in character.
4	**Almost all public goods.** Social and infrastructural spending almost entirely takes the form of public goods.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1900–2024

Convergence: Model parameters with convergence issues: universal thresholds.

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.1.3.3 EMB autonomy (C)

`v2elembaut`

Project Manager(s): Staffan I. Lindberg

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Does the Election Management Body (EMB) have autonomy from government to apply election laws and administrative rules impartially in national elections?

Clarification: The EMB refers to whatever body (or bodies) is charged with administering national elections.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**No.** The EMB is controlled by the incumbent government, the military, or other de facto ruling body.
1	**Somewhat.** The EMB has some autonomy on some issues but on critical issues that influence the outcome of elections, the EMB is partial to the de facto ruling body.
2	**Ambiguous.** The EMB has some autonomy but is also partial, and it is unclear to what extent this influences the outcome of the election.
3	**Almost.** The EMB has autonomy and acts impartially almost all the time. It may be influenced by the de facto ruling body in some minor ways that do not influence the outcome of elections.
4	**Yes.** The EMB is autonomous and impartially applies elections laws and administrative rules.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.1.3.7 Election vote buying (C)

`v2elvotbuy`

Project Manager(s): Staffan I. Lindberg

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: In this national election, was there evidence of vote and/or turnout buying?

Clarification: Vote and turnout buying refers to the distribution of money or gifts to individuals, families, or small groups in order to influence their decision to vote/not vote or whom to vote for. It does not include legislation targeted at specific constituencies, i.e. "porkbarrel" legislation.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Yes.** There was systematic, widespread, and almost nationwide vote/turnout buying by almost all parties and candidates.
1	**Yes, some.** There were non-systematic but rather common vote-buying efforts, even if only in some parts of the country or by one or a few parties.
2	**Restricted.** Money and/or personal gifts were distributed by parties or candidates but these offerings were more about meeting an 'entry-ticket' expectation and less about actual vote choice or turnout, even if a smaller number of individuals may also be persuaded.
3	**Almost none.** There was limited use of money and personal gifts, or these attempts were limited to a few small areas of the country. In all, they probably affected less than a few percent of voters.
4	**None.** There was no evidence of vote/turnout buying.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Mean
Date specific	Election-specific dates (`v2eltype`)
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.4.1.2 Executive bribery and corrupt exchanges (C)

`v2exbribe`

Project Manager(s): Jan Teorell

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: How routinely do members of the executive (the head of state, the head of government, and cabinet ministers), or their agents, grant favors in exchange for bribes, kickbacks, or other material inducements?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Routinely.** It is routine and expected.
1	**Often.** It happens more often than not.
2	**About half the time.** It happens about half the time.
3	**Occasionally.** It happens but is neither routine nor expected.
4	**Never, or hardly ever.** It never, or hardly ever, happens.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.4.1.3 Executive embezzlement and theft (C)

`v2exembez`

Project Manager(s): Jan Teorell

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: How often do members of the executive (the head of state, the head of government, and cabinet ministers), or their agents, steal, embezzle, or misappropriate public funds or other state resources for personal or family use?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Constantly.** It is routine and expected.
1	**Often.** It happens more often than not.
2	**Sometimes.** It happens about half the time.
3	**Occasionally.** It happens but is neither routine nor expected.
4	**Never, or hardly ever.** It never, or hardly ever, happens.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.4.1.1 Executive respects constitution (C)

`v2exrescon`

Project Manager(s): John Gerring

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Does the executive respect the constitution?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**No.** Members of the executive (the head of state, the head of government, and cabinet ministers) violate the constitution whenever they want to without legal consequences.
1	**Not really.** Members of the executive violate the constitution on most important matters without legal consequences, even if some provisions are respected.
2	**Somewhat.** Members of the executive comply with some important provisions of the constitution but there are also important provisions that are violated.
3	**Mostly.** Members of the executive comply with most provisions of the constitution, but may sometimes violate some provisions.
4	**Fully.** The executive is bound by and fully respects the constitution.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.8.1.11 Compliance with judiciary (C)

`v2jucomp`

Project Manager(s): Jeffrey Staton

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: How often does the government comply with important decisions by other courts with which it disagrees?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Never.** The government ignores decisions that it dislikes.
1	**Seldom.**
2	**About half the time.**
3	**Usually.**
4	**Always.** The government always complies, even when it disagrees.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.8.1.6 Judicial corruption decision (C)

`v2jucorrdc`

Project Manager(s): Jeffrey Staton

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: How often do judges decide cases in ways that appear motivated by their personal financial interests or by material inducements?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Always.** Exposed to corruption, judges always decide in the interest of the bribing party, regardless of the law.
1	**Usually.**
2	**About half the time.**
3	**Not usually.**
4	**Never.** Judges never decide cases based on financial interests or material inducements.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.8.1.10 Compliance with high court (C)

`v2juhccomp`

Project Manager(s): Jeffrey Staton

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: How often does the government comply with important decisions of the high court with which it disagrees?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Never.** The government ignores decisions of the high court that it dislikes.
1	**Seldom.**
2	**About half the time.**
3	**Usually.**
4	**Always.** The government always complies with high court decisions, even when it disagrees.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.8.1.8 High court independence (C)

`v2juhcind`

Project Manager(s): Jeffrey Staton

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: When the high court in the judicial system is ruling in cases that are salient to the government, how often would you say that the party or parties in power influence the ruling?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Always.** The high court always rules in favor of the government, regardless of its party or ideological position.
1	**Usually.**
2	**About half the time.**
3	**Seldom.**
4	**Never.** The high court is never influenced by the government, regardless of its party or ideological position.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.8.1.9 Lower court independence (C)

`v2juncind`

Project Manager(s): Jeffrey Staton

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: When judges in the lower courts are ruling in cases that are salient to the government, how often would you say that the party or parties in power influence the ruling?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Always.** Lower court judges always rule in favor of the government, regardless of its party or ideological position.
1	**Usually.**
2	**About half the time.**
3	**Seldom.**
4	**Never.** Lower court judges are never influenced by the government, regardless of its party or ideological position.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.6.1.6 Legislature corrupt activities (C)

`v2lgcrrpt`

Project Manager(s): Allen Hicken

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Do members of the legislature abuse their position for financial gain?

Clarification: This includes any of the following: accepting bribes, helping to obtain government contracts for firms in which they have a financial interest, doing favors for firms in exchange for the promise of future employment, stealing money from the state or from campaign donations for personal use.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Commonly.** Most legislators are corrupt in at least one of the above senses.
1	**Often.** Many legislators are corrupt in at least one of the above senses.
2	**Sometimes.** Some legislators are corrupt in at least one of the above senses.
3	**Rarely.** Very few legislators are corrupt in any of the above senses.
4	**Never, or hardly ever.** No or virtually no legislators are corrupt in any of the above senses.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.6.1.8 Legislature controls resources (C)

`v2lgfunds`

Project Manager(s): Allen Hicken

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Does the legislature control the resources that finance its own internal operations and provide the basic endowments to perform its functions?

Clarification: This concerns the fiscal autonomy of the legislature, i.e. the legislature's ability to set its own budget and to have the resources to hire the staff and purchase the equipment necessary to fulfill its mandate.

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Not at all.** The legislature has no control over its own budget or resources. The executive controls the budget of the legislature.
1	**To a small extent.** The legislature has marginal control over its own budget and the resources it needs.
2	**To some extent.** The legislature has some control over its own budget and the resources it needs.
3	**To a large extent.** The legislature has substantial control over its own budget and resources.
4	**Entirely.** The legislature has full control over its own budget and resources, although the overall size of the budget may be determined by other actors.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.6.1.4 Legislature investigates in practice (C)

`v2lginvstp`

Project Manager(s): Allen Hicken

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: If the executive were engaged in unconstitutional, illegal, or unethical activity, how likely is it that a legislative body (party, committee, or plenary session) would conduct an investigation that would result in a decision or report that is unfavorable to the executive?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Extremely unlikely.**
1	**Unlikely.**
2	**As likely as not.**
3	**Likely.**
4	**Certain or near certain.**

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.6.1.5 Executive oversight (C)

`v2lgotovst`

Project Manager(s): Allen Hicken

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: If the executive were engaged in unconstitutional, illegal, or unethical activity, how likely is it that a party, legislature, judiciary, media, or other government body could, in practice, question or investigate the executive?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Extremely unlikely.**
1	**Unlikely.**
2	**As likely as not.**
3	**Likely.**
4	**Certain or near certain.**

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

3.2.1.7 Party linkages (C)

`v2psprlnks`

Project Manager(s): Allen Hicken

Additional versions: `*_osp, *_ord, *_codelow, *_codehigh, *_sd, *_mean, *_nr`

Question: Among the major parties, what is the main or most common form of party-constituency linkage?

Responses:

Code	Description
0	**Clientelistic.** Parties employ clientelistic strategies to mobilize voters. Voters are persuaded to vote for parties because of material benefits they receive in return, or because of coercion by party agents.
1	**Mixed clientelistic and local collective.** A mix of clientelistic appeals and locally-targeted collective goods.
2	**Local collective.** Parties win votes by promising or delivering locally-targeted collective goods to their supporters.
3	**Policy/programmatic.** Parties are linked to their constituents through policy/programmatic party platforms.
4	**Group identity.** Parties are linked to their constituents principally through group identity—e.g. ethnicity, religion, or class.

Scale	Ordinal, converted to interval by the measurement model
Data release	1–15
Cross-coder aggregation	Bayesian IRT measurement model
Country–Year Aggregation	Day-weighted mean
Years	1789–2024

Convergence: Model parameters with convergence issues: universal thresholds.

Citation: Pemstein et al. (2025); V-Dem Codebook (see suggested citation at the top of the V-Dem Codebook).

List of References

Coppedge, M., Gerring, J., Knutsen, C. H., Lindberg, S. I., Teorell, J., Altman, D., Angiolillo, F., Bernhard, M., Cornell, A., Gjerløw, H., Glynn, A., Grahn, S., Hicken, A., Kinzelbach, K., Marquardt, K., McMann, K., Mechkova, V., Medzihorsky, J., Neundorf, A., … Sundström, A. (2025). V-Dem Dataset v15. https://doi.org/10.23696/VDEMDS25

Marshall, M. G., & Gurr, T. R. (2020). Polity V Project: Political Regime Characteristics and Transitions, 1800-2018 [Available online at https://www.systemicpeace.org/inscr/p5manualv2018.pdf].

Miller, M., Boix, C., & Rosato, S. (2022). *Boix-Miller-Rosato Dichotomous Coding of Democracy, 1800-2020.* https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/FENWWR

World Bank. (n.d.). World Development Indicators. https://datacatalog.worldbank.org/dataset/world-development-indicators